HOWDENS GAME CHANGER PROGRAMME

ENGLAND FOOTBALL

Transforming kitchens for clubs and communities



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Howdens Game Changer Programme

Application Guidance For Clubs

TRANSFORMING KITCHENS FOR CLUBS AND COMMUNITIES.



Welcome

HOWDENS AND THE FA HAVE EXTENDED THEIR PARTNERSHIP FOR ANOTHER YEAR TO OFFER MORE GRASSROOTS CLUBS THE OPPORTUNITY TO APPLY FOR A HOWDENS KITCHEN.

We know that whatever the weather, refreshments go down well and enable clubs to generate much needed revenue.

The FA and Howdens have extended the award-winning Howdens Game Changer Programme for a further year, providing even more grassroots football clubs with the opportunity to transform their clubhouse facilities through a brand-new kitchen.

Since launching the programme, Howdens has committed more than £3 million worth of kitchens to grassroots football, supporting over 400 clubs with free kitchen installations. These upgrades have helped clubs enhance their facilities, strengthen their role at the heart of the community and create new revenue-generating opportunities.

We are delighted to continue our partnership with Howdens and announce a further £1 million investment in grassroots football through the programme. For the first time, eligibility will also be extended to clubs competing across the Men's and Women's National League System, enabling more clubs than ever before to benefit from this transformative support.

Applications for the 2026 Howdens Game Changer Programme will open on 1st September 2026 and close on 31st October 2026.

James Kendall
Director of Football Development
The FA



About the programme

HOWDENS HAVE PARTNERED WITH THE FA TO INVEST £3M INTO IMPROVING GRASSROOTS CLUB'S KITCHENS, WITH A FURTHER £1M NOW SECURED

Club facilities are the beating heart of local communities and football brings people together.

ABOUT THE PROGRAMME

In 2023, Howdens partnered with The FA to invest £3M into improving grassroots club's kitchens so that they can serve their communities with food and refreshments. Now, Howdens have committed to investing a further £1M into the programme, helping to fund even more kitchens and support more clubs.

Providing high-quality facilities not only provides vital refreshments to players and spectators, but it also enables clubs to generate additional income which can then be re-invested back into the club for the benefit of all.

We want to support projects that will replace or enhance your current kitchen and the food and drink that can be offered.

By inviting clubs to apply for the Game Changer Programme, we would like applications to demonstrate how the improvements will connect with your communities and make the best use of the skills within your club.

Who can apply?

WHO CAN APPLY?
England Football Accredited clubs who:

- Are 2* or 3* Accredited
- Are 1* Accredited and have a minimum of six teams

We are delighted to confirm that England Football Accredited National League Pyramid clubs across the men's and women's pathways are also now eligible to apply.

In addition the club must:

- Own their facilities freehold or
- Have a lease of five years or longer and have your landlord's consent to undertake the proposed works or
- Have a licence in place for the next five years with landlord consent to carry out the works

If you do not have the freehold or a lease of five years or longer then we would accept the freeholder as a joint applicant. This could include Local Authorities, County Football Associations, registered charities, not-for-profit companies, community interest companies (CIC) or other social enterprises, and town and parish councils.

Applications will be considered where the applicant has a lease of five years or longer but it contains a break clause in favour of the landlord. We will consider these types of applications if clubs can evidence a history of ongoing site usage.

If your club plays within the National League Pyramid and your proposal forms part of a wider project within the stadium, which may include funding from the Premier League Stadium Fund (PLSF), it is important that you speak to your PLSF Technical Manager before submitting your application to discuss the scheme in further detail.

Please note, if your application is linked to a wider PLSF application, the security of tenure requirements for PLSF is ten years.

Clubs that have received a kitchen through an earlier round may apply for a second kitchen where they can demonstrate sufficient demand.

Who can't apply?

WHO CAN'T APPLY?
You can't apply if you're:

- Not a 2* or 3* England Football Accredited club
- Not a 1* England Football Accredited club with a minimum of six teams
- An individual or sole trader
- A national governing body
- A club within the Premier League or Football League
- Educational establishments providing facilities solely for their students
- A Local Authority
- A professional club community organisation



What we will support

If successful, Howdens will be responsible for the supply of the kitchen. This includes the cabinets, drawers, hinges, handles, frontals, cabinet rims, worktops, sinks, taps and appliances.

Priority will be given to applications that include a nominated fitter that will install the kitchen on a voluntary basis (or a professional fitter funded by the club) and applications that provide more detail on the impact a new kitchen would have on their club.

However, in the event of a club not being able to source a local tradesperson to install the kitchen, there is the option for Howdens to support the installation by identifying a suitable tradesperson.

Additional works to kitchen space including preparation work would need to be either carried out or paid for by the club.

WHAT WE WILL NOT SUPPORT

The following items and services will not be included in the scope for Howdens to deliver and clubs should make provisions to have the work completed themselves:

- Plumbing and electrical work required to get the space ready for install and bringing it up to the relevant standards. This work should be carried out prior to the fit of the kitchen being arranged.
- Flooring repairs or installation. If the flooring is to be replaced, the club will need to confirm the specification to determine if the flooring needs to be installed before or after the kitchen installation.
- Any decoration work required on completion of the kitchen installation.
- The club will need to source any furniture e.g. chairs, stools, tables etc.
- Freestanding small domestic appliances such as toasters, kettles, air fryers and commercial catering water boilers will need to be arranged by the club.
- Structural works required e.g. moving of walls, doors or windows.





What do you need to consider before getting started on your application?

THINGS TO CONSIDER:

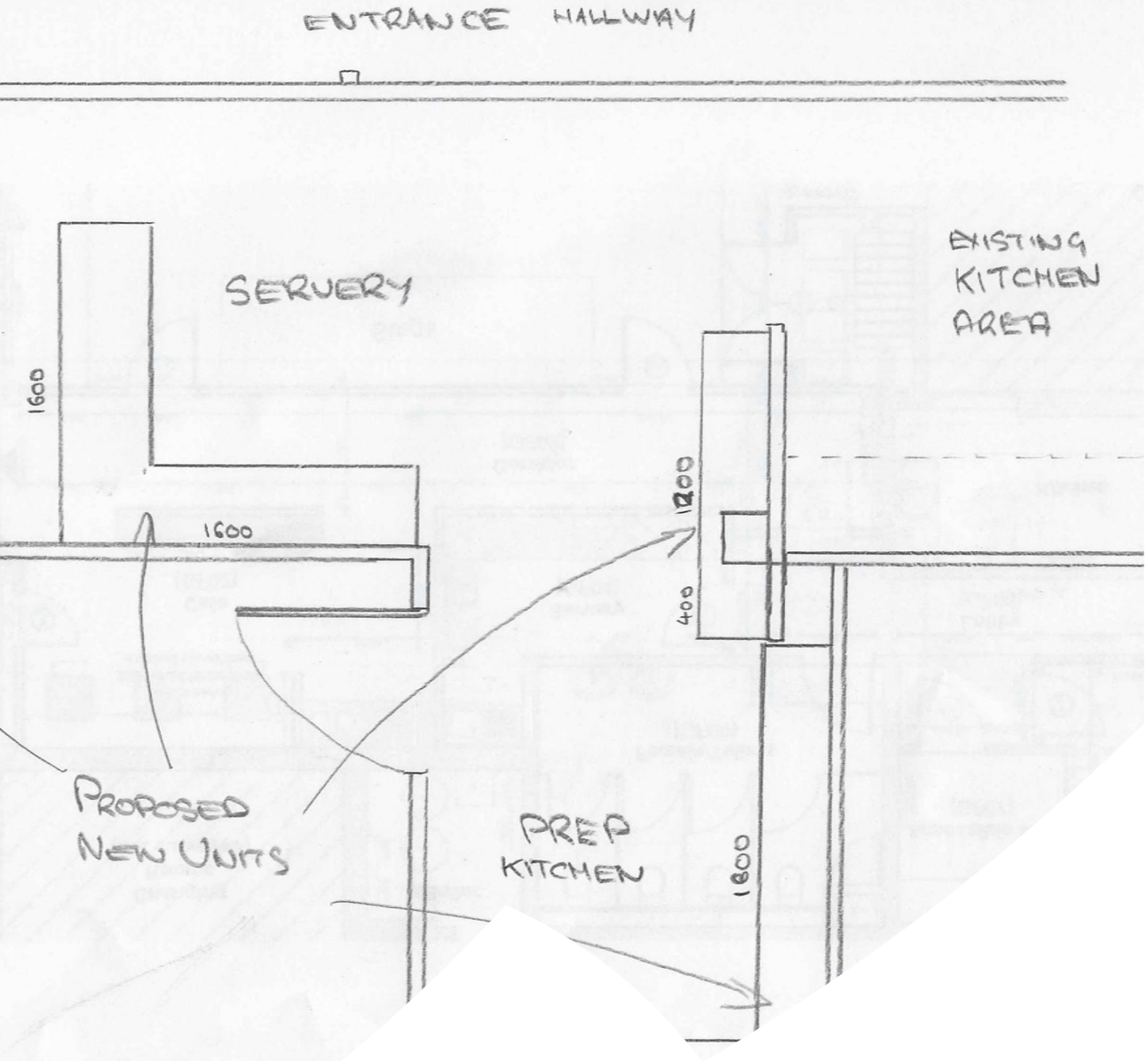
- This programme provides domestic kitchens. Is this suitable for your site? National League Pyramid clubs requiring funding for a commercial kitchen should consider PLSF by clicking here.
- Do you have a project team who can develop your application and project?
- Does your kitchen work for you now and does it create revenue?
- Are there opportunities to enhance your current food and refreshments offer?
- How do you currently manage the kitchen and how do you plan to manage it in the future?
- Have you carried out any research into what food and refreshments players and spectators want?
- What appliances and equipment would you need to enhance your current food and refreshment offer?
- Do you know a contractor or kitchen fitter who you could nominate on your application?
- When would you plan to carry out the works?
- Can you describe the space, how it is used and what your ideas and requirements are for the new kitchen?
- New build pavilions/clubhouses will be considered if the building works are going to be completed by the end of August 2027 and fit out cost of the kitchen are not already included in the project.

TYPES OF PROJECTS WE WANT TO FUND

We know that club kitchens come in all shapes and sizes so if your application is approved, you will be assigned a Kitchen Designer from your local Howdens Depot to design your kitchen and develop your project.

EXAMPLES COULD INCLUDE:

- A straight like for like upgrade of your kitchen to modernise it, the layout is right, but the kitchen needs replacement.
- The creation of a servery and preparation areas to facilitate the high flow of customers.
- An external servery hatch so that spectators can access food and refreshments from outside of the building.
- Upgrading an existing metal container or modular building if it is watertight, already connected to the mains water (and waste drainage) and has an electricity supply.



Getting started with your application

You can access the application form by clicking here.

Please note, the application form should be completed and submitted, there is no way of saving it and returning to complete it at a later stage.

Please make sure you have the following information to hand when you start the application.

WHAT WILL YOU NEED TO INCLUDE WITH YOUR APPLICATION?

- A dimensioned sketch plan of the space detailing size of room, including width, depth, ceiling height and estimated m^2 measurements. Please highlight the location of existing plumbing, waste, water, electrics and gas connections
- Position of doors, radiators, windows, servery locations, and obstructions including width, depth and height measurements
- Photos of any existing kitchen, plumbing, electrical and gas services, as well as where the kitchen is to be fitted
- Evidence of security of tenure in the form of a signed lease, licence or freehold title document
- Landlord's consent to carry out the works
- Building and contents insurance

Please upload these documents with your application. However, if there is any reason that you are unable to, please forward the documents at your earliest convenience to: **howdens@footballfoundation.org.uk**

We cannot assess your application without these.

You may be required to supply the following documents, depending on the age and condition of where you plan to install the kitchen. These could include:

- A building condition survey of the existing building and accessibility of the facility
- Building regulations approval where required
- Any relevant planning approvals
- Current food hygiene rating (if applicable)
- Food hygiene qualifications (if kitchen operator is already qualified)

Getting started with your application (Cont'd)

HOW WILL YOUR APPLICATION BE ASSESSED?

Your application will be assessed during November and December 2026 with decision in February 2027. You might be contacted by the assessment team during this time to clarify the information you have submitted.

There is likely to be high demand for this programme and therefore your application will be assessed and prioritised against the following criteria:

- Clubs who demonstrate the greatest need and whose project will have the greatest impact on their local community
- Clubs that provide opportunities across multiple pathways e.g. male, female and disability football
- How clubs intend to operate and maximise usage of their kitchen to generate additional income for the club
- Clubs that nominate a contractor / fitter that will install the kitchen on a voluntary basis (or a professional fitter funded by the club)
- Clubs that open up their kitchen for wider community use
- Clubs that have 3G pitches or multiple grass pitches on one site
- Applicants that have not previously received a kitchen through this programme

IF YOU ARE SUCCESSFUL, WHAT HAPPENS NEXT?

A letter will be sent to you with an award pack detailing the next steps.

Successful applications will need to be signed and accepted by two members associated with the club of which one should be the primary contact that completed the application form.

All relevant information relating to award acceptance will be shared in the award letter. You will be able to start your project once any pre-commencement conditions have been met (if applicable).

You will need to have an on-site meeting (or meetings) between the Club Representative, a representative from your local Howdens Depot and your contractor / fitter to bring the project to life. This will include:

1. Completing a site survey to confirm kitchen dimensions, location and requirements
2. Confirming which kitchen range, worktops, sinks and taps, handles and appliances will be used in the design
3. Confirming any pre-install work that the club needs to arrange and have carried out prior to the kitchen installation e.g. flooring, plumbing or electrical works
4. The representative from your local depot will develop the design and present it back to the club and contractor / fitter. This may take a couple of iterations but will be managed by the depot and the Game Changer Programme project team
5. Following sign off of the design, you will need to confirm to your local depot when any pre-fit work will be completed and when the contractor / fitter will be available to begin the installation
6. Upon confirmation of the install date, your local depot will ensure the stock is available and if appropriate arrange delivery. The representative at your local depot will be on hand to help if needed during the installation

As part of the award, the club will also be required to engage in communications promoting the Game Changer Programme such as social media content, an opening event and other publicity. Further details will be provided in the award pack.

FA/Howdens – FAQS

WHAT CAN WE USE THE AWARD FOR?

There is no monetary grant award, if successful you will be awarded a fitted kitchen from Howdens, this will include the cabinets, drawers, hinges, handles, frontals, cabinet trims, worktops, sinks, taps and appliances.

View range here.

CAN THE PROJECT INCLUDE REFURBISHMENT OR REDECORATION OF THE BUILDING?

No, the club would be responsible for getting the kitchen area ready for the kitchen to be fitted and for any subsequent redecoration. The following is a non-exhaustive list of matters the club would be responsible for:

- Plumbing and electrical work, including upgrades
- Flooring repairs or flooring installation
- Decoration after the install of the kitchen
- Any furniture (chairs, stools, tables etc)
- Freestanding small domestic appliances such as toasters, kettles, air fryers
- All structural works (moving walls, doors, windows)
- Ensuring that all electrical and gas works must be carried out by a qualified and certified contractor

WHAT DO WE NEED TO ACCEPT OUR AWARD?

Successful applications will need to be signed and accepted by two members associated with the club of which one should be the primary contact that completed the application form. All relevant information relating to award acceptance will be shared in the award letter. In the event of a joint application, two signatures would be required from both organisations. You will be able to start your project once any pre-commencement conditions have been met.

HOW LONG DO WE HAVE TO ACCEPT OUR AWARD ONCE NOTIFIED OF A SUCCESSFUL APPLICATION?

You will have one month to accept the award and six months to start your project from the date of your award letter.

HOW WILL THE PROJECT BE MONITORED ONCE THE KITCHEN HAS BEEN INSTALLED?

Clubs will be surveyed upon completion of the project. We want to understand your experience of the programme so that we can continually improve our processes. On an annual basis we will contact you to find out the impact the kitchen has had on your club.

ELIGIBILITY/ APPLICATION PROCESS

WHEN IS THE APPLICATION WINDOW OPEN?

The window opens 1st September 2026 and will close on 31st October 2026.

IS THE APPLICATION PROCESS COMPLICATED? HOW LONG WILL IT TAKE TO FILL OUT THE APPLICATION FORM?

It is a very straightforward process and should take no more than 20 minutes to complete. However, you will need to gather and provide the supporting information below:

- A dimensioned sketch plan of the space detailing size of room including width, depth, ceiling height and estimated m^2 measurements. Please highlight the location of existing plumbing, waste, water, electrics and gas connections
- Position of doors, radiators, windows, servery locations, obstructions including width, height and depth measurements
- Photos of any existing kitchen, plumbing, electrical and gas services as well as where the kitchen is to be fitted
- Evidence of security of tenure in the form of a signed lease, licence or freehold title document
- Landlord's consent to carry out the works
- Building and contents insurance
- Estimate of the total revenue generated by your kitchen currently (if applicable)

DO WE NEED TO APPOINT A BID CONSULTANT TO HELP US WITH THE APPLICATION?

No, there is no need to engage any professional support to complete this application. The application form is simple to complete and should only be completed by an authorised member of your organisation.

ARE WE ELIGIBLE TO APPLY TO THE PROGRAMME?

Football clubs who:

- Are 2* or 3* England Football Accredited
- Are 1* England Football Accredited and have a minimum of six teams
- Are England Football Accredited and compete in the National League Pyramid
- County FAs are also eligible

FA/Howdens – FAQS (Cont'd)

WHAT SECURITY OF TENURE IS REQUIRED?
Applications for kitchens must be from sites that:

- Own their facilities freehold or
- Have a lease of five years or longer and have your landlord's consent to undertake the proposed works or
- Have a licence in place for the next five years with landlord consent to carry out the works

If you do not have the freehold or a lease of five years or longer then we would accept the freeholder as a joint applicant. This could include Local Authorities, County Football Associations, registered charities, not-for-profit companies, community interest companies (CIC) or other social enterprises, and town and parish councils.

Applications will be considered where the applicant has a lease of five years or longer but it contains a break clause in favour of the landlord. We will consider these types of applications if clubs can evidence a history of ongoing site usage.

WHAT IF I DON'T NOMINATE A CONTRACTOR / FITTER ON MY APPLICATION?
Priority will be given to applications that include a nominated fitter that will install the kitchen on a voluntary basis (or a professional fitter funded by the club). However, in the event of a club not being able to source a local tradesperson to install the kitchen, there is the option for Howdens to support the installation by identifying a suitable tradesperson for the club to work with.

WE DELIVER ACTIVITIES AT MORE THAN ONE FACILITY; CAN WE APPLY FOR FUNDING FOR EACH OF THE SITES?
Clubs that have received a kitchen through an earlier round may apply for a second kitchen where they can demonstrate sufficient demand.



FA/Howdens – FAQS (Cont'd)

HOW DO I APPLY?
You can access the application form by clicking here.

Applications made by third parties on a club's behalf, or through any third-party websites, will not be considered.

WE'VE ALREADY RECEIVED FOOTBALL FOUNDATION FUNDING PREVIOUSLY, ARE WE ELIGIBLE TO APPLY?
Yes, if you meet our eligibility criteria (detailed on page 19-20).

WHEN WILL WE KNOW IF WE'VE BEEN SUCCESSFUL?
We'll contact you with the decision on your application by the end of April 2027.

IF SUCCESSFUL, WHEN WOULD THE KITCHEN NEED TO BE INSTALLED?
During this window, the expectation is for kitchens to be installed between March - August 2027, subject to Howdens availability.

WE HAVE ALREADY STARTED TO DO SOME OF THE WORK, WHAT SHOULD WE DO?
If you've already started the installation of a kitchen, then you would be ineligible to apply. If the works relates only to the preparation of the kitchen area, then you may still apply.

IF WE ARE UNSUCCESSFUL, WHEN WILL WE BE ELIGIBLE TO APPLY AGAIN?
This is the fourth year of the partnership, therefore we are unable to guarantee future windows at this point.

WHY HAS THE APPLICATION BEEN REJECTED?
It is most likely your application has been rejected for one of the following reasons:

- Your club type isn't eligible
- You may not have the required security of tenure for this programme
- You are not 2* or 3* England Football Accredited club, or 1* England Football Accredited club with a minimum of six teams
- The building condition isn't suitable for installation at this time

THERE ARE OTHER WORKS THAT WE NEED TO CARRY OUT – CAN WE APPLY FOR FUNDING FOR THOSE AS WELL?
No, the Game Changer Programme is only for the kitchen which includes the cabinets, drawers, hinges, handles, frontals, cabinet trims, worktops, sinks, taps and appliances. There might be other funding available to support other works you might wish to carry out, but this will be separate to the Game Changer Programme.

WHO CAN WE CONTACT ABOUT THE APPLICATION?
If you have a question that hasn't been answered in these FAQs, or require support with an application, then please contact your County FA facilities team. They are on hand to support you through the application process and answer any other questions that you may have.

Once submitted, your application will be administered by the Football Foundation who are funded by The FA, the Premier League and Government via Sport England. If you have any queries regarding the application form please contact: **howdens@footballfoundation.org.uk**

THE FUND

WHO HAS FUNDED THIS PROGRAMME?
This programme is being funded by Howdens as a partnership with The FA. The application process is being administered by The Football Foundation.

WHAT IS THE AIM OF THIS FUND?
The aim of the fund is to support England Football Accredited clubs to improve their kitchen facilities so that they can offer food and refreshments to players and spectators.

OTHER SUPPORT

CAN WE STILL APPLY FOR A FACILITY GRANT FROM THE FOOTBALL FOUNDATION?
Yes, this does not affect your ability to apply for any other funding from the Football Foundation.


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